

## HOMES PAST AND FUTURE

You're a 40-year-old New York lawyer, Miami realtor, or Denver oil man. That one-bedroom condo you bought fifteen years ago was a fuzzy blanket that helped you mature. Later, the big house served as a secure place to raise kids, relax, watch TV, and feed the multitudes. Over the years you've made \$200,000, \$500,000, or more by trading up on your homes.

But whatever your home has meant in the past, when you retire you look to the future. Your home was a super investment? Great. But it may be a lousy investment now. And you don't need super investments. All you need are safe, high-yield, trouble-free CDs that throw off enough cash to live on. Your home helped impress customers? Great. But when you retire you won't have any customers. You needed lots of space to feel comfortable? Great. But you're about to embark on a new adventure. What you require from your living space will change. To process that change, you need an open, uncluttered mind more than a mansion that costs a pile. You need freedom rather than the security a big house can seem to give.

For those with \$400,000 to \$500,000 of net worth, the choice is simple. Do you want a big house with the right address or life without work right now? If you grind away at the office for two or three more decades you may be able to afford both. But in most cases, to retire young you have to choose.

The following chapter describes some exciting places where you can live cheaply. But when you sell your expensive crib you're bound to feel you're giving up something. Decide for yourself which you prefer: an expensive house and the job that goes with it, or a modest living space and time to do something new with your life.